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The 720: APAC CL, MediaTek, Japan WFE, Kioxia, China Semis & SPE, Largan, APAC Energy, China Hog, Japan IT Services initiations

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In Focus | APAC Conviction List

APAC Conviction List – July Update. We add KB Financial, Hyundai Mobis, NetEase, and ResMed to the APAC Conviction List, while removing TSMC, Alibaba, Mao Geping, APR, and Fisher & Paykel. Sinyoung Park argues that KBFG's strengthening operating momentum amidst the ongoing rate hike cycle is not fully appreciated by the market. Do Hyoung Kim expects Hyundai Mobis to re-rate as the market shifts its view on the company's transition from a cyclical auto-parts supplier to a humanoid actuator player. Lincoln Kong expects NetEase to differentiate itself as a disciplined "non-AI" compounder - trading at 12-13x forward P/E, Lincoln argues that current valuations present a solid entry opportunity ahead of the new game launch on July 9th. Davin Thillainathan believes ResMed is well-placed for a re-rate with levers in place, with the stock trading at a ~200bps discount to global MedTech peers. *Michael Snaith*

Listen Up - GS Webcasts on the Agenda

Global Technology: Key Trends, Debates, 2H Outlook | 8pm HK | Access Webinar | with Jim Schneider, Michael Ng, Mark Delaney, Daiki Takayama, Allen Chang, Shuhei Nakamura; Verena Jeng; Giuni Lee; Alex Duval, Peter Callahan

Technology | MediaTek, Japan WFE, Kioxia, China Semis & SPE, Largan, Korea Tech, Toto

MediaTek – Stronger AI ASIC momentum reshapes growth – Buy. We see stronger AI ASIC momentum beginning in 2027 and raise our 2027E AI ASIC revenue forecast to US$20.3bn, significantly above the company's high-end guidance. We also factor in a 5% price hike starting in 3Q26 to cover elevated supply chain costs, which should keep gross margins largely steady. Reflecting the stronger AI ASIC outlook and higher pricing, we revise up our 2027-28E EPS by 38% and 4%, respectively. We raise our 12m TP to NT$6,800 from NT$5,000. *Evelyn Yu*

Japan WFE – 2H CY26 Investment Strategy – Buy Lasertec (on CL), Ebara, Disco, TEL. We raise our 12m TPs for our 10 covered semiconductor production equipment companies by an average of 16%, reflecting upward revisions to capex forecasts by memory majors. We expect the wafer fab equipment market to grow by 32% yoy in CY27, driving continued earnings expectation increases for the sector. Heading into the second half of CY26, we highlight Buy-rated Lasertec (on CL), Ebara, Disco, and Tokyo Electron, focusing on companies with high likelihoods of beating market consensus. We also reinstate coverage on Kokusai Electric at Neutral with a 12m TP of ¥9,500, as expectations for upside to FY27 earnings appear largely priced in. *Shuhei Nakamura*

Kioxia – Ongoing NAND Supply Tightness – Buy. We raise our FY27-FY29 OP estimates by 9% to 29% and EPS estimates by 10% to 29% to reflect the recent NAND market supply and demand environment. We now forecast ASP to grow 4.5x yoy in CY26 and 38% in CY27, as major memory makers prioritize DRAM investment and new NAND fab supply remains limited. The company is prioritizing prices and margins, and we believe it can maintain relatively high profit margins within the industry given its low capital intensity. We raise our 12m TP to ¥116,000 from ¥93,000. *Shuhei Nakamura*

China Semis – Capacity expansion drives growth ahead. We are constructive on China SPE and semiconductor material names, supported by advanced node capacity expansion and generative AI trends that are driving domestic ecosystem development. To capture long-term growth opportunities from rising customer capex and increasing localization, we shift our valuation methodology to a 2030E discounted P/E framework. Driven by this methodology change and upward earnings revisions reflecting higher AI-related contributions, we raise our 12m TPs for JCET to Rmb125, AccoTest to Rmb630, and Hwatsing to Rmb395, while maintaining Neutral ratings across all three names. *Allen Chang*

China SPE – Valuation framework reset on better long-term visibility. We remain constructive on China SPE and semiconductor material names, driven by rising advanced node capacity expansion and generative AI demand. Following reports of a long-term server DRAM supply agreement between CXMT and Tencent, we see strong demand from local clients supporting the domestic ecosystem. We shift our valuation methodology to a 2030E discounted P/E to reflect better long-term visibility from rising customer capex and localization. Consequently, we maintain Buy ratings and raise our 12m TPs for NAURA to Rmb1,200, AMEC to Rmb573, ACM Research to US$164, and Anji Micro to Rmb509. *Allen Chang*

Hua Hong – Migration and expansion amid AI – Buy. We remain constructive on the company's growth trajectory and margin improvement, supported by growing semiconductor demand for AI applications and local data center power supply. We raise our 2027E to 2029E net income estimates by 1% to 8% to reflect higher 28nm revenues and improved operational efficiency from larger scale. We expect operating margins to turn positive to 1% in 2026E and expand to 12% by 2029E as new 12-inch fab capacity ramps up and product mix upgrades toward high-end applications. We maintain our Buy rating and raise our 12m TP to HK$333 from HK$174. *Allen Chang*

Largan – Handset Lens Upgrades and CPO Expansion – Buy. We are positive on the company's expansion into CPO lenses for AI infrastructure, which diversifies the business away from the competitive smartphone market and supports a re-rating. We see its focus on high-end handset lenses benefiting from the growing vision AI trend in smartphones, allowing it to outperform amid high memory costs. We raise our 2026-2028E net income estimates by 6%-11% to reflect stronger handset lens shipments, pixel mix upgrades, and the CPO lens expansion. We raise our 12m TP to NT$6,231 from NT$3,423. *Verena Jeng*

Korea Tech – 3Q26 DRAM ASP forecast inline, NAND lower. TrendForce expects 3Q26 conventional DRAM ASP to increase by 13-18% quarter-over-quarter, which is in line with our 16% growth estimate for Samsung Electronics. However, the 10-15% quarter-over-quarter growth forecast for NAND ASP tracks lower than our 21% estimate, as suppliers adopt a more moderate pricing strategy for consumer eMMC/UFS. PC and server DRAM pricing forecasts remain strong due to low inventory levels and expectations of tight supply in 2027. We reiterate our Buy rating on Samsung Electronics with a 12m TP of W480,000. *Giuni Lee*

Japan Housing & Building Materials – Raising Toto TP on NAND market growth. We update our estimates for four Japan housing equipment companies to reflect April 2026 data, raising our 12m TP for Toto to ¥11,100 from ¥6,900 (Buy) and for LIXIL to ¥2,000 from ¥1,900 (Neutral). We roll forward our valuation base year for Toto to FY3/29, anticipating sustainable growth in its ceramics business driven by rising NAND demand for AI data centers and higher capital investment by key semiconductor clients. While China real estate completions remain weak, domestic sanitary ware shipments surged on last-minute demand, and we see the negative impact of the naphtha shortage on LIXIL as relatively minor. *Sachiko Okada*

Themes in Play | APAC Energy, China Hog, Sony, India Consumer, ANZ Gold, Korea Insurance, Indigo

APAC Energy & Chemicals – Refining Leads Preference Sequence Amid Hormuz Reopening. We highlight a preference sequence of refining, followed by upstream, and then chemicals, driven by tight product inventories and refining capacity re-emerging as a bottleneck. We lift our 2026E/27E Singapore GRM forecasts to US$23.2/13.9 per bbl, reflecting a delay in global refinery run normalization to September, and prefer pure-play Asian refiners like Buy-rated S-Oil (on CL), Thai Oil, and Reliance. In upstream, we upgrade ONGC to Neutral with a 12m TP of Rs270, as shares now price in a lower Brent forecast, while we downgrade Siam Cement to Sell with a 12m TP of Bt185 due to stretched valuations in a structurally oversupplied ethylene chain. *Nikhil Bhandari*

India Clean Energy – Grid Tech: Prefer Schneider, Neutral on Hitachi. We raise our earnings estimates and 12m TPs for Schneider Electric Infra (Buy, Rs1,475) and Hitachi Energy India (Neutral, Rs30,350) to reflect larger addressable opportunities in data centers and battery energy storage systems. We prefer Schneider as it remains in the early stage of its order growth cycle, and we raise our order inflow assumptions to a 31% CAGR over FY26-29E, driving 13% EBITDA upgrades over FY28E. Conversely, while we raise Hitachi's EBITDA estimates by 5-14% over FY27-28E on improved margin expansion visibility, we estimate its order book-to-bill ratio already peaked in FY25, leaving less scope for further valuation multiple expansion. *Nikhil Bhandari*

China Agriculture – Hog cycle - deteriorated cash runway suggests accelerating supply response and price inflection ahead – Buy Muyuan. We believe the Chinese hog sector is at a cyclical bottom, with nearly all producers operating at a cash loss and rapidly shortening cash runways pointing to an accelerating supply response. With nearly 50% of listed producers estimated to have less than six months of cash runway by the end of 2Q26, we expect accelerating sow-herd reductions and supply exits to drive a 5% market supply deficit in 2H26E. We expect a price rebound to Rmb15.0/kg in 2H26E, and Rmb15.3/kg for 2027E, versus current spot of Rmb9.4/kg. We maintain Buy on Muyuan given its attractive risk/reward below replacement cost, while remaining Neutral on Wens and NHL. *Trina Chen*

Sony Group – Ending disc production for new PS games – Buy. We note Sony announced it will end disc production for new PlayStation games starting in January 2028, shifting to a digital-only format for new releases. We believe this move aligns with management's focus on profitable growth, as digital versions carry higher margins and the shift could capture sales from the used game market. We think this transition will positively impact earnings for both Sony and game publishers. We maintain our Buy rating and 12m TP of ¥4,100. *Minami Munakata*

India Consumer – 1QFY27 FMCG and Paints Preview. We expect aggregate revenue growth across our FMCG coverage to accelerate in 1QFY27, driven primarily by price increases in the home and personal care segment to offset input-cost inflation while volumes remain resilient. We expect Nestle, Tata Consumer, and Marico to lead year-on-year EBITDA growth supported by softer input costs, whereas GCPL, HUL, and Emami are poised for strong revenue acceleration aided by a favorable base. Conversely, we expect ITC to see a sharp cigarette profit decline of approximately 25% due to the peak impact of higher taxes, and United Spirits to face muted growth and margin pressure from glass-cost inflation. *Also see Titan Co. – Earnings Tailwinds from Falling Gold Prices – Buy*. *Arnab Mitra*

Australia Metals & Mining – Gold Buy vs. Build Analysis. We find that building new gold projects remains broadly more attractive than buying, as gold price increases continue to outpace cost inflation and support project returns. However, the capital intensity of building Australian gold projects has roughly doubled over the past 3-5 years, which alongside a recent pullback in equities has narrowed the gap and should keep M&A in focus. With the number of gold mill projects in construction set to more than triple against CY25 levels, we see growing risks around capex, timeline delays, and execution quality due to emerging constraints in skilled labor and equipment. *Hugo Nicolaci*

Korea Insurance – 2Q26E Preview. We expect non-lifers' earnings to remain steady due to improving loss ratio trends and normalizing investment profits, and we revise up our 2026E-28E earnings estimates and 12m TPs by 1% on average. We believe scheduled reform measures effective from July 2026, including a general agencies commission cap and tighter claims controls, will fundamentally improve insurers' earnings quality and profitability. Furthermore, we expect insurers to substantially refine their Value Up plans in the second half, which should reward them with higher valuation multiples. We reiterate our Buy ratings on Samsung F&M, DB Insurance, and Hyundai M&F, viewing progress on Value Up as a key share price driver. *Sinyoung Park*

InterGlobe Aviation – Reduced Cost Headwinds Set Up Market Leader – Buy. We expect the airline sector to benefit from abating cost headwinds and recovering traffic as capacity returns. We decrease our FY27 EPS estimate by 27% but increase FY28 EPS by 13%, reflecting near-term elevated refining spreads followed by a promising setup in outer years. As normalcy returns, we see the company continuing its market share lead and growing revenue in the early double digits over the medium term. We raise our 12m TP to Rs5,800 from Rs5,300. *Pulkit Patni*

Japan IT Services initiations | Baycurrent (Buy), Money Forward (Sell), Internet Initiative Japan (Neutral), SHIFT (Neutral)

Baycurrent – Initiate at Buy on Strong AI and Security Consulting Demand. We initiate coverage on Baycurrent at Buy with a 12m TP of ¥8,100, forecasting an operating profit

CAGR of +25% over FY2/26-29E that comfortably surpasses the sector average. This above-market growth is driven by the company's strong hiring capabilities, a flexible one-pool assignment system that maintains high consultant utilization, and expanding demand for AI implementation support and cybersecurity measures. We believe the earnings impact from industry-wide AI disruption will be limited, as rule-based operations account for only about 1% of sales. Furthermore, the company's core focus on hands-on project management support involves complex human decision-making that is very difficult to replace with generative AI. *Chikai Tanaka*

Money Forward – Initiate at Sell on Valuation and AI Disruption Risks. We initiate coverage on Money Forward at Sell with a 12m TP of ¥3,500, as we believe its high profit growth potential is largely factored into the share price. We forecast operating profits to break even in FY11/26 and turn profitable in FY11/27, with strong growth continuing from FY11/28 driven by corporate cloud accounting expansion and AI-driven cost efficiencies. However, the stock lacks valuation appeal at current levels, and we note industry-wide concerns regarding AI disruption. Specifically, while accounting and HR software replacement risk appears low, we see a certain degree of risk that generative AI could substitute demand for tax filing software used by sole proprietors. *Chikai Tanaka*

Internet Initiative Japan – Initiate at Neutral as AI Drives Network Demand. We initiate coverage on Internet Initiative Japan at Neutral with a 12m TP of ¥3,000, as we believe its high profit growth potential is largely priced in. We project a medium-term operating profit CAGR of +10% over FY3/26-29E, driven by the expanding network infrastructure construction market and successful cross-selling of network services. Because the company focuses on network infrastructure rather than proprietary software, we view the expansion of data traffic from increasing AI adoption as a structural tailwind for demand. *Chikai Tanaka*

SHIFT – Initiate at Neutral on AI Disruption Risks in Software Testing. We initiate coverage on SHIFT at Neutral with a 12m TP of ¥710, as we see a high risk of AI disruption in its core software testing business. We forecast FY8/26 operating profits of ¥17 bn, below guidance due to margin deterioration from AI investments. However, we expect profit growth to accelerate to ¥20.5 bn in FY8/27, largely driven by a lighter fixed cost burden resulting from strict hiring restraints as the company adapts to the evolving AI landscape. *Chikai Tanaka*

APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day | Chagee, Mengniu Dairy, Eastroc, Weilong

Chagee – New products support SSSG stabilization – Neutral. Management targets SSSG to turn positive in 4Q26, supported by new product launches like beer-like tea and lemon milk tea which contributed approximately 15% to GMV. We note April-May monthly per-store GMV reached Rmb350k, implying a mid-teens percentage SSSG decline, while June saw sequential improvement. The company aims to lower its delivery mix to 40-50% to drive dine-in traffic and is testing its new Geelato category with plans to expand to nearly 200 stores this summer. We maintain Neutral with a 12m TP of US$13.6. *Xinyu Ruan*

Mengniu Dairy – Healthy recovery and growth acceleration across categories – Buy. Management expressed growing confidence in a broad-based recovery for 2026, with liquid milk maintaining high-single-digit year-to-date growth and fresh milk accelerating to over 30% growth. The company sees upside to its full-year guidance of mid-single-digit revenue growth, driven by proactive engagement in emerging channels and disciplined promotions. Management prudently maintains its core OPM target of 8.0%, utilizing stringent operating expense savings to offset potential mild raw milk cost increases in the second half. We reiterate Buy with a 12m TP of HK$24.0. *Leaf Liu*

Eastroc Beverage – Multi-Category Growth Intact Despite 2Q Headwinds – Buy. We expect a 3Q26 re-acceleration in energy drink shipments following weather and capacity-related headwinds in 2Q26, driven by new low-sugar SKUs and holiday promotions. The multi-category strategy continues to deliver strong growth, led by Guozhicha and Daka, while gross margins are set to expand on favorable PET costs and scale efficiencies. 12m TP of Rmb159.7. *Leaf Liu*

Weilong Delicious Global Holdings – Softer 1H26 but Vegetable Snacks Accelerate – Buy. We note 1H26 sales tracked below initial expectations due to softer consumption, though 2026 margin guidance remains intact. We remain constructive on vegetable-based snacks, with new konjac flavors and stinky tofu showing strong growth, offsetting pressures in seasoned flour. The company is restructuring to balance offline and online channel growth, while maintaining a 60% baseline dividend payout with potential for special dividends. We maintain our 12m TP of HK$14.0. *Valerie Zhou*

Event | Ajinomoto

Ajinomoto – ABF business briefing: Demand tracks ahead of guidance – Buy. Management noted that functional materials sales are trending ahead of the FY3/27 guidance for a 10% yoy increase, driven by sustained strong demand for ABF. The company is developing peripheral materials, with magnetic materials expected to contribute commercially by improving AI server power efficiency. To address next-generation packaging like co-packaged optics, Ajinomoto plans to establish a de facto standard by advancing ABF and new materials. 12m TP of ¥6,500. *Takashi Miyazaki*

Asia Macro | Korea, China

Korea Macro – Government Doubles Down on AI Support. Korean government announced the “3 Mega Projects,” a joint-ministerial initiative outlining massive public-private investments across semiconductors, physical AI, and AI data centers. Combined with long-term plans from Samsung and SK Group, we expect total AI-related investments to reach roughly KRW380trn per annum over the next decade, averaging about 10% of GDP. Separately, the government announced KRW1trn in fiscal spending for price stabilization, including fuel-price cap cuts and utility freezes, which we expect to be reflected mostly in July CPI. *Irene Choi*

China Macro – Domestic Onshore Marketing Takeaways. We find onshore investors have grown more cautious on near-term growth momentum following weaker April-May activity data and a bifurcated growth mix. Policy easing expectations remain subdued, with clients anticipating support to stay reactive rather than proactive unless downside risks intensify. Discussions also highlighted fragile consumer confidence amid labor-market pressures and the negative wealth effect from the property downturn, alongside implementation risks around new cross-border investment rules. *Yuting Yang*

Around the World | US & EU Convictions Lists, US Hardware, US Macro

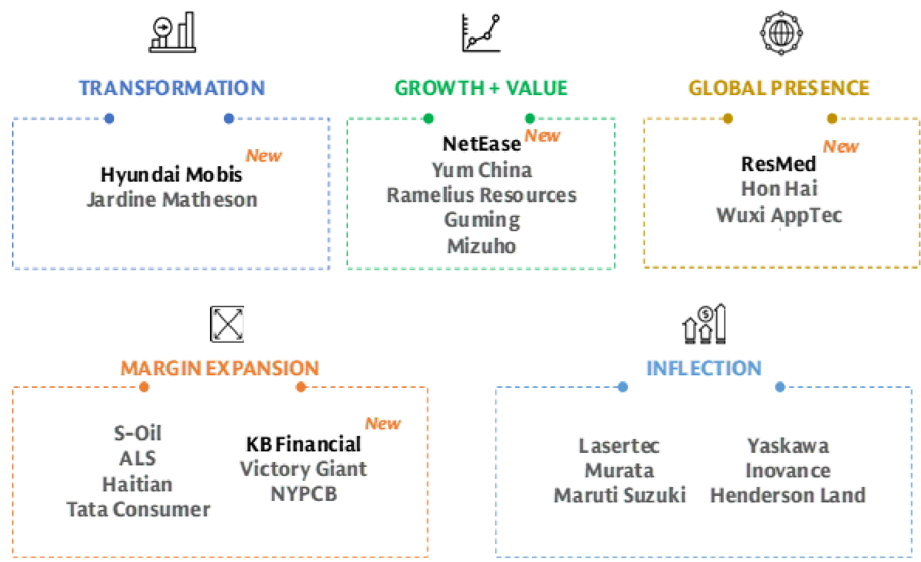
US Conviction List – July 2026 Update. We add Estee Lauder, Nextpower, and Wells Fargo to the US Conviction List, while removing Brixmor Property Group, Duke Energy, and nVENT Electric. For Estee Lauder, Bonnie Herzog expects an innovation-driven topline inflection and internal initiatives to drive 450 basis points of margin expansion over the next three years. Brian Lee views Nextpower as favorably positioned to sustain long-term growth as its business model evolves from a pure-play solar tracker into a broader power technology platform. Finally, Richard Ramsden sees Wells Fargo shifting from defense to offense, benefiting from balance sheet expansion, a strong capital markets backdrop, and concerted cost controls to fuel operating leverage. *Steven Kron*

European Conviction List – July 2026 Update. We add TGS and Halma to the Conviction List while removing Bayer, ABI, and DT. Michele della Vigna expects seismic player TGS to be an early beneficiary of rising oil capex and a return to frontier investment, forecasting its multi-client division to grow 19% year-over-year in FY26. Christian Hinderaker views Halma as a high-quality growth compounder with strong pricing power in regulated markets, and sees a compelling entry point following its recent de-rating. *Jessica Binder Graham*

US Hardware – Data center and campus networking preview. We update our industry networking model to reflect upgraded outlooks for the AI Ethernet data center switching and campus networking markets, driven by the growing complexity of AI builds and network modernization needs. Heading into C2Q26 earnings, we believe Arista Networks and Celestica are well positioned despite recent underperformance, as demand for AI Ethernet switches should remain robust and benefit long-term growth. We also remain constructive on Hewlett Packard Enterprise given positive synergies in its campus portfolio post-Juniper acquisition. We maintain Buy ratings on ANET, HPE, and CLS, and a Neutral rating on CSCO. *Michael Ng*

US Macro – Lessons from the ICT Revolution for the AI Era. We expect AI to meaningfully boost productivity growth over the next decade, likely materializing faster than the 8 to 12-year lag seen during the ICT revolution as AI model costs fall more rapidly. While hardware investment is already rising sharply, human and institutional obstacles to adoption, alongside the need for complementary intangible organizational capital, will likely delay the macro impact. We believe industries such as information, professional services, insurance, and finance are positioned to show the earliest and largest pickups in productivity growth. *Elsie Peng*

Graphic Language | APAC Conviction List - Anatomy of the List



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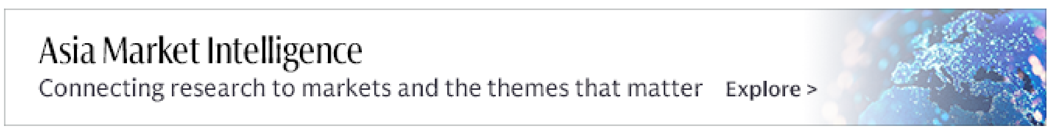

GS Events (Home Page here)

- **APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day | Hong Kong |** 29 Jun-3 Jul
- **Korea Corporate Day | Singapore |** 6-7 Jul
- **Asia Leaders Conference | Hong Kong** | 31 Aug-2 Sep
- **Asia Healthcare CDMO Day | Singapore |** 23-25 Sep
- **Japan Conference | Tokyo |** 30 Nov - 4 Dec

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